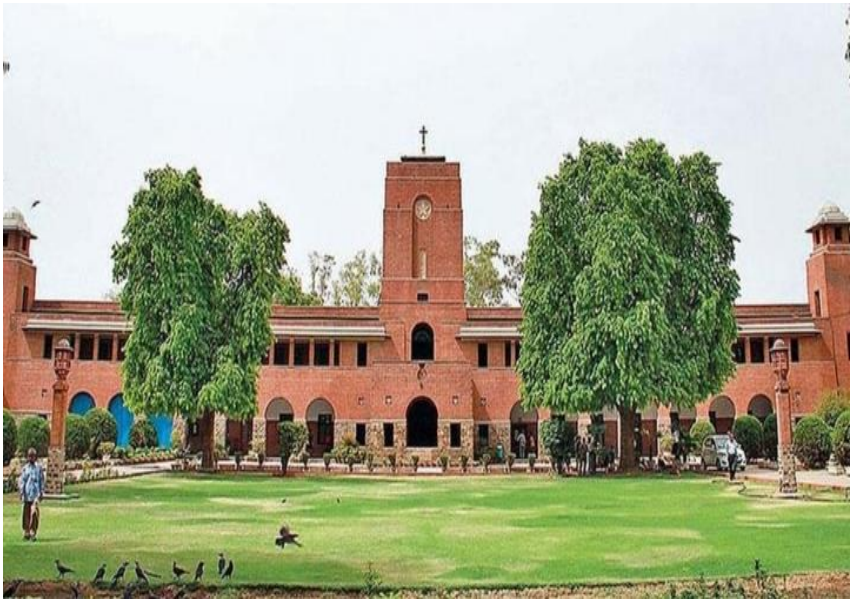
The Hidden Struggles of DU Students: Beyond the Classroom

Introduction: Attendance pressure, expensive accommodation, patriarchy and financial difficulties reveal the challenges students face beyond academics.

College life is often considered one of the most exciting phases of a person's life. It brings new friendships, opportunities, independence and the chance to explore different interests. For students at the University of Delhi (DU), entering college is often the beginning of a new journey towards building a career and discovering themselves.

However, behind the photographs of campus events, crowded canteens and cheerful gatherings, many students deal with challenges that are rarely discussed. From attendance requirements and expensive paying guest (PG) accommodation to family restrictions and financial pressure, university life can be far more complicated than it appears.

For students who have moved to Delhi from other cities, the experience can be especially demanding. They must adjust to a new environment while managing their education, accommodation, expenses and personal responsibilities.



"For many students, Delhi University represents opportunity,

independence and a new beginning."

Attendance: The Pressure to Be Present

Attendance is one of the common concerns among university students. Although regular attendance supports classroom learning, maintaining it can become difficult for students dealing with long commutes, health issues, family responsibilities and other commitments.

Many students spend hours travelling to college every day. A delay in the metro, crowded buses or traffic congestion can affect their schedules. By the time they reach campus, they may already be tired, yet they are expected to manage lectures, assignments and practical work.

For journalism students, academic responsibilities often extend beyond the classroom. Reporting assignments, internships, photography and event coverage require additional time and effort. Balancing these activities with regular classes can be challenging.

The Issue is not whether attendance matters, but whether students receive clear information and appropriate guidance when genuine difficulties affect their attendance. Transparent policies can help students plan their schedules and understand academic requirements.



“Managing attendance alongside assignments and other responsibilities can be challenging for university students.”

⭐Women and Patriarchy: Is Education Enough?

For many women, studying at a university represents an important step towards independence. Higher education can provide opportunities to build careers, develop confidence and make decisions about their futures.

However, traditional gender expectations can continue to influence women's experiences even after they enter college. Some women students face restrictions on travelling alone, returning home late, choosing accommodation or participating in activities outside regular college hours.

These restrictions may arise from concerns about safety, family expectations or social norms. While safety is a genuine concern, women can sometimes find themselves with fewer opportunities because they are expected to limit their movements rather than enjoy the same freedom as their male peers.

For example, a woman student may have to leave a college event early or decline an internship because of travel restrictions or curfews. Such decisions can affect not only her social life but also her academic and professional development.

This creates an important contradiction: women may be encouraged to pursue higher education, yet their independence can remain restricted. Education should not simply provide a degree; it should also enable students to develop the confidence and freedom to pursue their ambitions.

Families, universities and authorities must work towards safer environments where women can study and participate in college life without unnecessary restrictions.



"For some women students, pursuing education also means

negotiating family expectations and restrictions on independence."

⭐The PG Problem: High Rent and Brokerage:

Finding affordable accommodation is another major challenge for students moving to Delhi. University hostels may not be available to everyone, forcing students to look for private hostels, PG facilities or rented rooms.

The financial burden often begins before students move in. Apart from monthly rent, they may have to pay security deposits, brokerage charges, electricity bills and additional fees for food or maintenance. These expenses can place significant pressure on families already paying for education.

Accommodation problems are not limited to money. Students must also consider cleanliness, food quality, water supply, room-sharing arrangements and distance from college. Some may face strict entry timings or other rules that affect their daily routines.

For women students, finding accommodation can involve additional concerns about safety and restrictions. An affordable PG may have inconvenient timings, while a more suitable option may be too expensive.

Students should have access to transparent pricing, written agreements and clear information about deposits and refund policies. Colleges can also help by providing reliable accommodation guidance.

A place to live is essential for students studying away from home. Finding one should not become an additional source of uncertainty and financial stress.



“Finding affordable and suitable accommodation remains an important concern for students living away from home.”

⭐The financial Burden of Student Life:

University expenses extend beyond tuition fees. Transportation, food, books, stationery, printing, internet access and educational activities all require money. Students living away from home must also manage rent and other daily necessities.

Financial limitations can affect the opportunities students pursue. Some may hesitate to accept unpaid internships because of travel expenses, while others may avoid workshops or college activities that require additional spending.

This can create differences in the university experience. Students with greater financial support may find it easier to explore internships and professional opportunities, while others must prioritise essential expenses.

Financial pressure can also create emotional stress, particularly when students are trying to balance family expectations with their own ambitions. Scholarships, accessible financial assistance and affordable educational opportunities can help reduce these difficulties.



“Rent, transport, food and study materials add to the cost of university life.”

⭐Beyond the Classroom:

The challenges faced by DU students show that university life is about much more than lectures and examinations. Attendance, accommodation, gender expectations and financial limitations can all influence a student’s ability to make the most of higher education.

These difficulties should not overshadow the opportunities university provides. Instead, recognising them can help institutions create a more supportive environment for students from different backgrounds.

Clear academic policies, affordable accommodation, accessible student support and safer commuting options can make a meaningful difference. Listening to students' experiences is equally important because their concerns reveal what needs attention.

Behind every student attending a lecture is a different story of ambition, responsibility and determination. For some, college is a relatively smooth transition into adulthood. For others, it involves constant compromises between education, finances, family expectations and personal freedom.

A meaningful university experience should not be measured only by admission or academic performance. It should also be measured by whether students have a fair opportunity to learn, participate and build the future they want.



'Despite the challenges, university life continues to offer students opportunities for learning, friendship and growth."